Level Up: a rooftop commons on a Sengkang car park

Tactical urbanism proposal · Singapore · Development of Intelligent Cities

Site selection

Sengkang is one of Singapore's newest HDB towns. Its housing blocks share multi-storey car parks (MSCPs) sized for car demand forecast decades ago. HDB reports season-parking take-up of only 50–70% in Sengkang and Punggol (about 66% island-wide), so the uncovered top deck — the hottest, furthest and least wanted level — often sits almost empty. At the same time, new towns cluster shops and gathering places around transport hubs, leaving few informal places to meet close to home. The top deck is the opposite: flat, built to carry load, reachable by lift, a few metres from thousands of residents, with open views and an evening breeze. It is a space nobody uses, right next to people who need space.

Conceptual project

"Level Up" is a 12-weekend pilot that turns the top deck into a neighbourhood commons on Friday–Sunday evenings (6–10 pm) and early weekend mornings, when Singapore's heat eases. Everything is movable and cheap: tension shade sails, pallet seating, modular planters, string lights and paint. The deck is split into four zones: **Shade & Grow** (planter crates families adopt), **Makan** (a small evening market for home-based businesses and neighbourhood hawkers), **Play** (a painted pickleball/futsal court, a chalk strip for children, tai chi for seniors at sunrise) and **Sunset Screen** (films and talks projected on the stair-core wall). Parking on the levels below is untouched.

Residents co-design the layout at a "chalk the deck" day, drawing it full-size on the concrete. A QR voting board in the lift lobby lets anyone choose next weekend's programme, and volunteer "deck captains" run each night. As an intelligent-city layer, low-cost sensors log footfall, deck temperature and noise, and the car park's gantry data records occupancy. The pilot therefore produces open evidence: who came, whether neighbours were disturbed, and that no cars were displaced. Noise is managed with a 10 pm close, inward-facing speakers and a decibel limit.

Justification and impact

Singapore already has the channels to scale the idea. The URA–HDB Lively Places Fund supports ground-up public-space projects, and HDB has converted some MSCP rooftops into community gardens and urban farms under its Green Towns Programme. If the pilot data shows steady use and few complaints, the deck becomes permanent: a light solar canopy that shades the deck and generates power, fixed courts and garden beds, and a residents' committee to manage bookings. The pilot then becomes an open playbook for other under-used car-park roofs across the island.

Socially, it gives a dense new town a walkable "third place" where generations and neighbours meet. **Economically**, it offers home-based businesses a low-cost stall and keeps spending local. **Functionally**, it turns single-use parking into multi-use space without new land or construction; shade, planting and later solar reduce heat on the hottest surface in the estate, and community growing supports Singapore Food Story 2, which aims for local farms to supply 20% of vegetables and other fibre by 2035. Low cost and removable in a day if it fails — a model for hundreds of car-park roofs if it works.

Sources: MND parliamentary answers on MSCP utilisation and conversion (2022, 2025); URA Place Management / Lively Places Fund; SFA, Singapore Food Story 2 (Nov 2025). Visualization: see presentation website.